SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #67 · HELL

“If I die with an unconfessed sin, I will go to hell.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that forgiveness only covers sins you specifically confess. Fear of dying suddenly before you can confess. A sensitive conscience that keeps searching for unconfessed sins. Stories meant to frighten people into confession. Worry about loved ones who died suddenly.

What Scripture teaches

Confession is good and important; it restores closeness with God. But a believer’s salvation does not depend on confessing every sin before death. No one can even discern all their own errors; David prayed, “Cleanse me from my hidden faults.” When you trusted Christ, God forgave all your trespasses and canceled the debt against you, nailing it to the cross. By one offering, Christ has made perfect forever those who are being sanctified.

> *“When you were dead in your trespasses and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our trespasses, having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees that stood against us. He took it away, nailing it to the cross!”* **(Colossians 2:13–14)**.

Also see

> “Who can discern his own errors? Cleanse me from my hidden faults” **(Psalm 19:12)**.

> “Because by a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified” **(Hebrews 10:14)**.

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” **(Romans 8:1)**.

> “But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin” **(1 John 1:7)**.

Common self-statements

- I have to confess every sin or I’ll be lost.
- What if I forget one?
- If I die suddenly, I might go to hell.
- I can never relax until I’ve confessed everything.
- My salvation depends on my confession list.
- One missed sin could cost me heaven.

Common logical errors

- **Catastrophizing:** Imagining dying at the wrong moment and being lost.
- **Scrupulosity:** Searching endlessly for sins to confess.
- **Discounting Christ’s work:** Believing forgiveness depends on your perfect confession.
- **Perfectionism:** Believing your confession must be complete to count.

Challenging questions

- What did God do with all my trespasses when I came to Christ?
- Can anyone know all their own sins, according to Psalm 19:12?
- What did Christ's one offering accomplish for those being sanctified?
- Is my salvation based on my confession list or on Christ's cross?
- Why do I confess: to stay saved or to stay close to God?
- Does checking make me more peaceful or more fearful?
- What did the thief on the cross have time to confess?

Truth summary

> I will not go to hell because I die with an unconfessed sin. When I trusted Christ, God forgave all my trespasses and nailed my debt to the cross. Christ's one offering has made me perfect forever. I confess my sins to stay close to God, not to stay saved. My salvation rests on Jesus, not on a perfect list.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Confession
- Salvation
- Christ, Sacrifice of
- Forgiveness
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Belief/Salvation
- Death and Dying

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I die with an unconfessed sin, I will go to hell"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I die with an unconfessed sin, I will go to hell." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did God do with all my trespasses?
- ☐ Can anyone know all their sins?
- ☐ What did Christ's one offering accomplish?
- ☐ Is salvation based on my list or the cross?
- ☐ Do I confess to stay saved or stay close?
- ☐ What did the thief on the cross confess?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God forgave all my trespasses through Christ.
- ☐ My debt was nailed to the cross.
- ☐ Christ's one offering has made me perfect forever.
- ☐ I confess to stay close to God, not to stay saved.
- ☐ God cleanses me even from hidden faults.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Colossians 2:13–14**
  "When you were dead in your trespasses and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our trespasses, having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees that stood against us. He took it away, nailing it to the cross!"
- [ ] **Psalm 19:12**
  "Who can discern his own errors? Cleanse me from my hidden faults."
- [ ] **Hebrews 10:14**
  "Because by a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified."
- [ ] **Romans 8:1**
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- [ ] **1 John 1:7**
  "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Rest log:** Each night, pray Psalm 19:12 once: "Cleanse me from my hidden faults," and then rest instead of reviewing my day.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Colossians 2:13–14 becomes: "When **Sarah** was dead in **her** trespasses, God made **her** alive with Christ. He forgave **her** all **her** trespasses, having canceled the debt ascribed to **her**. He took it away, nailing it to the cross!"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Confession" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Each night this week, pray one simple prayer** of confession and thanks, then stop reviewing your day.
- ☐ **Read Luke 23:39–43,** and notice what the thief had time to do before Jesus promised him Paradise.
- ☐ **Write Colossians 2:14 on a card** and read it when the fear comes.
- ☐ **Talk with a pastor or Christian counselor** if checking for sins has become a burden.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I die with an unconfessed sin, I will go to hell": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One night I rested instead of checking
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I die with an unconfessed sin, I will go to hell.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You forgave all my trespasses and nailed my debt to the cross. Help me reject the lie that dying with an unconfessed sin will send me to hell. Cleanse me from hidden faults, help me confess freely to stay close to You, and let me rest in Christ's finished work. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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